Weeks after the truce, I interviewed desperate families living in the rubble of their homes, or in squalid tents by the roadside; when I returned to the same neighborhoods two years later, some of those same families were still there. A friend had moved to Nahal Oz not long after the war. On a visit to the kibbutz one evening, he pointed out the eerie darkness across the border. Even electricity remains in short supply in Gaza.

So Hamas' main accomplishment was simply to survive, to briefly interrupt flights out of Tel Aviv and to continue firing rockets on Tel Aviv until the final moments of the war. But they claimed victory nonetheless, and enjoyed a major short-term bump in popularity as a result. A post-war poll by the Palestine Center for Policy and Survey Research found Haniyeh to be vastly more popular than Mahmoud Abbas.[32] It was an "unprecedented" boost for the group, the largest since 2006, according to Dr Khalil Shikaki, the director of the center.

Not so on the other side. There was no Israeli counterpart to the jubilant press conference outside the hospital; in fact there was no press conference at all, not until more than 24 hours later. Netanyahu did not put the ceasefire to a cabinet vote, because he wanted to avoid the embarrassing spectacle of half his cabinet voting "no". Instead he accepted the truce unilaterally, notifying ministers in a series of rushed phone calls. When he addressed the public on 27 August, he looked exhausted and sounded defensive. Asked if the war would bring lasting quiet to southern Israel, he ducked the question, saying only that the "blows that Hamas has suffered and our ability to prevent their resurgence in the future… increase the chances of achieving that goal."

A poll broadcast on Channel 2 found that 54 per cent of Israelis opposed the truce, and only 29 per cent felt they had defeated Hamas during the conflict. Criticism came in from across the political spectrum, even from within his own Likud party: Danon accused him of ending the fight with Israel "shamed and confused." It was an ignominious end to Netanyahu's first major war as prime minister—and to a remarkable period of unity within the country.

The disappearing war

There is an old story, probably apocryphal, about a foreign diplomat who met an Israeli official in the early years after independence. The minister